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Milestone 1 Reflection

Our prototype is a simple cat-and-mouse game where the player controls a cute little mouse that gathers cheese while trying to escape the cat chasing it around the house. In this prototype, we focused on creating the environment of the game (the cozy home the mouse and cat live in) and the mobility of the mouse (how it moves around, animations, and the overall feel of playing as the mouse). We imported designs from the Unity Asset Store, applied materials, and arranged the models to create the cozy home shown in this prototype. We imported the models of the mouse and cat, but left the cat stationary for now, as our focus for this prototype was on the movement of the mouse. We used the New Input System asset to detect the player's input (WASD or arrow keys) and Cinemachine to have the camera follow the mouse model and allow players to move the camera's angle using cursor movements.

By implementing this player movement system with the mouse character and camera tracking, it allows the player to feel immersed in the world of the game through responsive character and camera inputs, as well as maintain a sense of position within the world. Borrowing from Swink's "Context Metrics" from *Game Feel* (2009), we made certain design choices that would help contextualize the spatial world of the game and the mouse's place in it. The world was designed to be a cozy small home that matches the light-hearted vibe of the game. However, the furniture of this home is scaled up to simulate the perspective of a small mouse living in this home. To further this feel, we ensured that the mouse had low orbital dampening and a small dead zone to indicate to the player the small size and fast speed of the little mouse. Our focus on the environment and vibes of the game is our strategic way of

integrating narrative into the game. In “Game Design as Narrative Architecture” from *In First Person: New Media as Story, Performance, and Game* (2004), Jenkins highlights four ways of embedding narrative in space. We were most aligned with enacting stories, where the narrative is performed by players moving across a geography. The background of the familiar mouse-and-cat conflict sets the stage for the game for the beginning and the end, but the player’s actions are what inform the middle of that narrative.

In the process of creating the prototype for this game, we struggled the most with implementing Cinemachine. While getting a working and even tracking camera was not too difficult, we encountered many issues in trying to make the camera movement feel smooth in conjunction with the player’s movements. For example, at first, the camera could track the mouse model, but the player’s cursor movements had no effect on the angle of the camera. After some more attempts, we were able to get the camera to move with cursor movement, but it would shift the camera rather than turn the camera (shifting the position of the camera rather than changing the angle, similar to how a head would turn). Finally, after even more attempts, we got the camera to work a little smoother and turn like a head naturally would. There are still some things we’d like to tweak, such as locking the camera cursor, adding more restraints to how much the camera can turn, as well as adjusting the movement of the mouse so that it aligns with the perspective of the camera (e.g. when you press W or up arrow but are looking sideways from where the mouse model is facing, the model adjusts to look to where the camera is looking forward and accordingly moves forward). However, for the focus of this prototype, we settled on this current camera setup and will attempt to improve on it in further prototypes.

Luckily, there were not many compromises to the design of our game that had to occur in the process of creating this prototype. Other than the difficulties in implementing Cinemachine, the only other challenge was the mouse movement animations. The model we

downloaded did include mouse animations. They are quite cartoony and unrealistic, as mice typically cannot barrel roll or other such feats of physical prowess. However, we determined this fit the fun, light-hearted vibe we wanted the game to have. The only other difficulty with these animations was adding small effects like a realistic/matching dust particle effect when the mouse sprints at a certain velocity.

With meticulous workshopping, we are overall happy with the prototype we created. We feel it accomplishes the goals and focus we set for this prototype, captures the core game feel in terms of mouse and camera movement, and gives a sense of the vibe we want for the final version of the game.

Bibliography

Jenkins, H. (2004). Game Design as Narrative Architecture. In First Person: New Media as Story, Performance, and Game (pp. 118-130). The MIT Press.

Swink, S. (2009). Context metrics. In Game feel: A game designer's guide to virtual sensation (pp. 183–216). Morgan Kaufmann.

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Sound

- Mouse (move)
Sound Effect by freesound_community from Pixabay
- Background
Music by Nikita Kondrashev from Pixabay
- Jump (boing)
Sound Effect by Official Profile from Pixabay
- Land (thud)
Sound Effect by Dilip from Pixabay
- Roll (whoosh)
Sound Effect by DRAGON-STUDIO from Pixabay

Assets

- Cat
<https://assetstore.unity.com/packages/3d/characters/animals/mammals/casual-cat-classic-tabby-305464>
- Mouse
<https://assetstore.unity.com/packages/3d/characters/animals/mammals/mouse-quirky-series-180848>

- Furniture 1

<https://assetstore.unity.com/packages/3d/props/furniture/interiors-free-cozy-cartoon-pack-348260>

- Furniture 2

<https://assetstore.unity.com/packages/3d/props/furniture/low-poly-furniture-pack-free-by-igs-389770>

- Furniture 3

<https://assetstore.unity.com/packages/3d/props/furniture/cute-furniture-free-low-poly-3d-models-pack-260522>

- Food

<https://assetstore.unity.com/packages/3d/props/food/low-poly-food-pack-free-by-igs-394324>